the eastern theatre commenced on 29–30 November, and the Indo-Pak war broke out on the evening of 3 December 1971, when the Pakistan Air Force carried out a pre-emptive attack on our airfields, military and civilian targets. The retaliation by the Indian armed forces was swift and massive. All our service training institutions were temporarily shut down, except the training facilities for recruits and officer cadets. I was posted to Western Command and told to report at Jalandhar Cantonment, where the operational headquarters of Western Command had been established. I worked in the intelligence branch, which, as usual, was one of the most hard-pressed. Everyone wanted to have the latest information. It was a thankless yet challenging task to meet the demands of the Corps and Division HQs. In a short-duration war, real-time, hard and actionable intelligence is difficult to come by. But we tried our best.

Eventually, in the eastern theatre, the Pakistan armed forces were inflicted a crushing defeat. In a brilliant campaign, the Indian Army, Navy and Air Force, ably supported by the Mukti Bahini, the paramilitary forces, the BSF in particular, and people on both sides of the border, liberated Bangladesh. On 16 December 1971, the Pakistani forces formally and unconditionally surrendered and a new nation emerged. Bangladesh became a reality. For this brilliant land campaign, the credit rightly went to the armed forces leadership, in particular the army chief, General Sam Manekshaw; the GOC-in-C Eastern Command, Lieutenant General J.S. Aurora, his corps and division commanders and all other subordinate commanders and staff officers. I do not subscribe to the exaggerated claims for a larger-than-life role played by some other senior staff officers. We must not forget that in the defeat of 1962, the heads that rolled were of the army chief, the corps commander and other leaders, and not of their chiefs of staff or other advisers. The ultimate responsibility and accountability of achieving the mission rests on the shoulders of the commander concerned. On the western front, on 17 December 1971, a ceasefire was unilaterally declared by India and accepted by Pakistan. India had won a decisive victory,